The tianxia and developing-country leadership perspectives are increasingly backed by China's Great Power self-confidence. Chinese thinkers place their country in the same league as the US, especially since Xi Jinping's leadership. In 2014, under Xi, Beijing began to mention the possibility of a 'new type of great power relations' with Washington – which President Barack Obama pointedly ignored. Looking forward, Xi has made clear that his 'China Dream' is a dream about being number one in the world, not coeval with the US. Deng Xiaoping, who led China's economic reforms and its extraordinary rise, urged China to 'hide your strength, bide your time, never take the lead'. Xi's China Dream has effectively buried 'hide and bide'. Publicly Chinese policymakers dismiss any ambition to replace the US as the pre-eminent power and to restructure the reigning international order, but the ambition is clear enough.

Clearly, China does not see India as a fellow Great Power. This is not particularly surprising, in part because India itself does not use the term 'Great Power' to describe its status. India is trying to change its image from 'rising power' to 'leading power', but it has resisted staking a bigger claim. In a backhanded compliment, Beijing has periodically referred to India as an 'important power' (usually when India has pressed its claims for a permanent seat in the UN Security Council) but has refused to go any further. Zhang, the exponent of China as a unique civilizational state referred to earlier, dismisses all of India's claims to greatness: 'Although many in the West wish India to outperform China, arguing that India's democratic system is its trump card . . . this trump card is of dubious and poor quality, and India's gap with China is likely to grow further . . . China is a much better governed country.' Holding India back are five key weaknesses (most Indians would probably go along with the list): 'politicization of everything . . . populism prevails . . . India's 'soft state' . . . short-term politics . . . [and] schisms and disunity'. As a result, 'the gap between the two Asian giants could not be larger'.[103]

At the height of the crisis in Ladakh in June 2020, the editor of the *Global Times*, Hu Xijin, wrote scathingly about India: 'Some Indians arrogantly believe that the modernization of Indian troops will allow them